Walls Within Walls: Reading *The Yellow Wallpaper*

Notes on Charlotte Perkins Gilman's story (1892)

Read quickly, *The Yellow Wallpaper* is a story about a woman who goes mad staring at ugly decor. Read slowly, it's a story about a prison so well furnished that nobody, including the prisoner, can see the bars. Everything around the narrator looks like comfort or care. Each piece of it is also a wall.

The story moves inward through those walls, from the outermost to the innermost, until there is nowhere left to go.

1. The house: class and money

The first sentence is about status. "It is very seldom that mere ordinary people like John and myself secure ancestral halls for the summer." They're a doctor and his wife, comfortably middle class, renting a "colonial mansion, a hereditary estate" on the cheap because the heirs are tied up in some legal trouble. They are borrowing gentility for three months.

The house runs on other people's work. Mary looks after the baby. Jennie keeps house. The gardeners have their own little cottages. The narrator's job, as she sees it, is "to dress and entertain, and order things," and she feels like "a comparative burden" for not managing even that.

Her illness is a well-off woman's illness, and so is her cure. Only a household with servants can afford to prescribe a woman complete rest. A working woman couldn't be "absolutely forbidden to 'work'." Notice the quotation marks: for her, "work" means writing, the one thing she actually wants to do.

She has no money of her own, no say over the lease, and no way to leave. Six years later Gilman made the argument directly in *Women and Economics* (1898): women's financial dependence on their husbands is the root of their confinement. This story is that argument, told as horror.

2. John: love as control

John is not a villain, which is what makes him frightening. He is "practical in the extreme," trusts only what can be "felt and seen and put down in figures," and he loves his wife. He carries her upstairs, reads to her, and calls her his darling.

He also schedules every hour of her day, chooses her room over her objections, forbids writing and visitors, and decides what she may think about. His love and his control are the same gesture, so she can't resist one without seeming to reject the other. When she tries, he has a sentence that ends the conversation: "I am a doctor, dear, and I know."

He talks to her as if she were a child: "little girl," "blessed little goose," "Bless her little heart!" And he isn't alone. Her brother, also a doctor, agrees with him, and the famous Weir Mitchell, whose rest cure Gilman herself endured, waits in the wings as the next step. John stands for a whole profession and a husband's authority, not just one bad man.

3. The room: a nursery, or a cell?

John picks the room at the top of the house for its air. The narrator calls it a nursery. Then she describes it: barred windows, "rings and things in the walls," a gate at the head of the stairs, a heavy bed nailed to the floor, plaster dug out, the floor gouged, the bedstead gnawed, the wallpaper torn off in patches "about as far as I can reach."

She has an innocent explanation for every detail. "How those children did tear about here!" The reader increasingly can't share it. The room looks less like a place for children than a place where someone was once kept, the kind of upstairs room where families hid a relative they called mad.

Gilman never says which is true. But by the last page, the room is being used for confinement again: the narrator brings in a rope, locks the door, and throws away the key.

4. The windows: a world she can only look at

Against the room stand the windows, and through them the loveliest writing in the story: the garden and its "deep-shaded arbors," the bay and the little wharf, the shaded lane, the winding road, open country "full of great elms and velvet meadows." This is the fresh air the cure promised. But she is only allowed to look at it.

Even early on, her imagination is at the glass. She "always fancies" she sees people walking in the paths, and John warns her against fancy. The windows serve as lookouts too, so she can watch for Jennie and hide her writing in time.

Then the inside takes over the outside. The woman from the wallpaper appears in every view: creeping down the lane, through the arbors, along the road, ducking under blackberry vines when a carriage passes, crossing the fields "as fast as a cloud shadow in a high wind." By the end the narrator doesn't want to look out at all, and doesn't want to go out either: "outside you have to creep on the ground, and everything is green instead of yellow." The world has become one more pane of the pattern.

5. The wallpaper: the wall inside her

The paper is the innermost wall, and the only thing in the story that stays consistent. It is always a sickly yellow. It always defies order, following no law "of radiation, or alternation, or repetition, or symmetry." It always seems alive: broken necks, "bulbous eyes," curves that "suddenly commit suicide." It always has two layers, a loud front pattern and a dim figure behind. And light always rules it. By day the figure is quiet, and by moonlight the front pattern "becomes bars."

She describes it first like an art critic and then like a doctor ("debased Romanesque with delirium tremens"). John diagnoses her, so she diagnoses the paper. It's the only patient she's allowed and the only thing she's permitted to study. All the intellect she's told to switch off goes into the pattern.

The words she uses for it fit her as well: lame, uncertain, confused, trapped. The woman behind the bars makes that literal. Then there are many women, and finally she is one of them.

The way out that isn't

On the last day, she strips the paper, ties herself with the rope, and creeps around the room in the long groove worn along the wall. She tells John she has "got out at last," and in a sense she has. She has escaped the pattern by becoming the woman in it. It is an escape from every outer wall into the innermost one.

The roles flip. John pounds on the door and cries for an axe. She speaks to him gently, as he spoke to her, and calls him "young man." Then he faints, the stock response of a Victorian heroine, "right across my path by the wall, so that I had to creep over him every time!"

Why it lasts

Gilman wrote from experience. She fell into a deep depression after her daughter was born in 1885 and was treated with the rest cure. The story is often read as a protest against that treatment, and it is one. It lasts because the protest is built into the structure. The house, the husband, the room, the view, and the paper are each reasonable on their own. Together they make a mind with no exit.

It also asks the reader to do what the narrator does: to look hard at a pattern, try to make it resolve, and notice what's been hiding behind it all along.